SALESFORCE EXPERIENCE CLOUD · ONE-PAGE SUMMARY · OCTOBER 2026

Customisation tiers for Salesforce websites

Where design work ends, where developer effort begins, and where customisation starts to put Salesforce upgrades at risk.

	TIER · WHO	WHAT CHANGES	CONSTRAINTS · WATCH FOR	UPGRADE RISK
1	**Configure** Admin, designer	Pages, standard components, navigation and audiences in Experience Builder. The Theme panel sets brand colours, fonts and heading styles, published as `--dxp` hooks. Anything an admin should change later belongs here.	Only the options Salesforce exposes: template layouts, standard sections and columns, and each component's Builder properties.	None
	BEFORE TIER 2 Align the Figma library to the design system: variables named after real hooks, SLDS colour steps, roles not hues, and only the states, anatomy and sizes components have.			
2	**Style** Designer, working from a verified hook inventory	VALUES AND PUBLISHED NAMES ONLY, NO NEW CSS RULES • **Global tokens** `--slds-g-*`: the theme. Reach every component at once • **Component hooks** `--slds-c-*`: per component. Only the ones its own stylesheet reads work • **SLDS utility classes** `slds-*`: spacing, text, grid, named in markup	NO HOOK EXISTS FOR label size and weight, checkbox size, border width, input padding, focus-ring shape, hover elevation. PROVE IT A hook can exist and do nothing: read the rendered value. Utilities have no responsive spacing or gap.	Low: re-verify each release
	DEVELOPER GATE Code, source control, testing and deployment from here down. A funding decision. **Test:** sets a value or names something published → Tier 2; writes a new CSS rule, class or selector → Tier 3.			
3	**Layout** Developer, designer	Custom theme layouts (header, footer, page frame) and page layouts, built from standard base components with regions authors fill in Builder, **and the CSS classes we write to style them**. `::part` only as a signed-off last resort.	Deployed as metadata, not edited in Builder. Responsiveness and accessibility become ours. Classes are project-prefixed and never select Salesforce classes or internals.	Low
4	**Component** Developer	New Lightning web components with their own markup, data (including Apex), logic and Builder properties, including a **rebuild** of a standard control when the design needs a look no hook reaches.	Browser security model and allow-lists. Performance, accessibility and caching become ours. A rebuild also takes on keyboard behaviour, validation and screen-reader support.	Low, owned by us
	UPGRADE GATE Depends on Salesforce internals that can change without notice. An architecture approval.			
5	**Override** Developer	Reaching past a standard component's supported interface: CSS aimed at internal markup, **private styling hooks** (`--slds-s-*`, `--_slds-*`), scripts that alter the page after load, undocumented behaviour.	WARNING SIGNS selectors on classes we did not write · `!important` · a private hook · found by inspecting markup · a copied and edited standard component. Breaks silently; not covered by support.	**High**

What building it showed

84%
of the button design's values reached with supported levers

70%
of the form controls' values reached

26
Figma variables named a wrong or non-existent hook on first import

The gap is not effort: it is properties no hook reaches. Decide it per value: **accept** the component, **change** the design, or **fund** a Tier 4 rebuild. Never drift into Tier 5.

Recommendations

1. **Align the design system** before designing screens, and audit each import.
2. **Design to what ships**, from a verified hook inventory, not the published list.
3. **Review before building, measure after:** read rendered values in a browser.
4. **Developer gate = funding decision;** upgrade gate = architecture approval.
5. **Keep a register** of every token and hook set, and anything past the upgrade gate. Retest each release.

Summary of *Customisation tiers for Salesforce websites*. Evidence from the MSD LWR prototype: Figma design-system import and skinning of lightning-button and five form controls, measured in headless Chrome.